Open Science, Closed Peer Review?*

Gary Charness, Anna Dreber, Daniel Evans, Adam Gill, Séverine Toussaert

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Abstract

Open science initiatives have gained traction in recent years. However, open *peer-review* practices, i.e., reforms that (i) modify the identifiability of stakeholders and (ii) establish channels for the open communication of information between stakeholders, have seen very little adoption in economics. In this paper, we explore the feasibility and desirability of such reforms. We present insights derived from survey data documenting the attitudes of 802 experimental/behavioral economists, a conceptual framework, a literature review, and cross-disciplinary data on current journal practices. On (i), most respondents support preserving anonymity for referees, but views about anonymity for authors and associate editors are mixed. On (ii), most respondents are open to publishing anonymized referee reports, sharing reports between referees, and allowing authors to appeal editorial decisions. Active reviewers, editors, and respondents from the US/Canada are generally less open to transparency reforms.

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1 Introduction

The open science movement in economics has seen success in recent years with the adoption of transparency initiatives on the production side of research, e.g., pre-analysis plans (Ferguson et al., 2023). However, little attention has been paid to transparency on the evaluation side, i.e., open *peer-review* practices. These practices can be divided into (i) those that modify the identifiability of authors, referees, and editors and (ii) those that facilitate the open communication of information between stakeholders. Assuming that journals aim to maximize the quality of the papers they publish, the optimal level of transparency is uncertain without knowing more about the (perceived) costs and benefits of various policies. In this paper, we leverage a survey of experimental/behavioral economists to learn how stakeholders reason about key trade-offs and whether the growing support for open science practices extends to peer review. We complement the survey with a conceptual framework, a literature review, and cross-disciplinary data on journal practices.

The take-up of open peer-review practices has been slow across disciplines (Wolfram et al., 2020), including economics. Among the top-5 economics and Economic Science Association (ESA) journals (Table 1), some disclose metadata and handling editor identities, but none reveal referee identities or publish referee reports. One notable exception to the pattern of slow take-up comes from the *Nature* journals. On identifiability, *Nature* began disclosing reviewer identities in 2016, subject to the consent of the authors and referees (Nature, 2019). Around 80% of papers identified at least one referee during the trial period, suggesting some openness to these practices. On open communication, *Nature Communications* began publishing referee reports in 2016, subject to author consent (Nature Communications, 2015). The opt-in rate rose from 60% in 2016 to 70% in 2021, after which the journal decided to publish all reports without exception (Nature Communications, 2016, 2022). In 2025, *Nature* announced a similar full disclosure policy (Nature, 2025).

Given the limited evidence from economics, we surveyed economists on their views about open peer-review practices as part of a larger survey on peer review (Charness et al., 2022). In this article, we use this data to examine the main arguments for and against open peer review. We focus on the attitudes of experimental/behavioral economists ($N = 802$), many of whom are ESA members and from whom we recorded a high response rate.

We document three main findings. First, on identifiability, most respondents support preserving anonymity for referees, but views about authors and associate editors are mixed. However, there is clear support for giving authors the option to request, ex-ante, that certain reviewers not be contacted. Second, regarding open communication, most respondents support publishing anonymized referee reports, sharing reports between referees, and opening a channel for authors to appeal editorial decisions. Third, in a latent class analysis, we find that responses cluster in three groups, which we label as Traditionalists (33% of respondents), Incremen-

Table 1: Transparency policies

	ESA journals		Top-5 journals					Other disciplines		
Identifiability	*Exp Econ*	*JESA*	*AER*	*ECMA*	*JPE*	*QJE*	*REStud*	*BMJ*	*Frontiers*[a]	*Nature*[b]
Blinded review	Single	Single	Single	Single	Single	Single	Single	Open	Single	Opt-in
Referee identity disclosed	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	✓	✓	Opt-in
Handling editor disclosed	–	–	✓	✓	✓	–	✓	✓	✓	–
Journal publishes list of referees	No	No	Full	Full	Full	Partial	Partial	Full	No	No
Authors can nominate referees	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	✓	✓	✓
Authors can oppose referees	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	✓	✓	✓
Conflict-of-interest policy for editors	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	–	✓	✓	✓	✓
Conflict-of-interest policy for referees	✓	✓	–	–	✓	–	–	✓	✓	✓
Disclosure										
Turnaround time statistics	–	–	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Acceptance/rejection statistics	–	–	✓	✓	✓	✓	–	✓	✓	✓
Manuscript received/decision dates	✓	✓	–	✓	–	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Public decision letters	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	✓	–	✓
Public referee reports	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	✓	–	✓
Signed public referee reports	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	✓	–	Opt-in
Prior manuscript versions	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	✓	–	–
Communication channels										
Policy on author appeals	✓	✓	–	✓	✓	–	–	✓	✓	✓
Interactive review	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	✓	–

Notes: For journal abbreviations and further information, please see Appendix A.4. The sources for many journal policies are available in Table A.6. ***a***: After acceptance, *Frontiers* publishes the names of referees who have recommended the manuscript for publication. ***b***: *Nature* allows authors to opt in to double-anonymity, while authors and referees must both agree for referee identities to be publicly shared. All *Nature* publications must now feature a peer-review file, which includes signed or unsigned reports and author responses, but only some files feature decision letters.

talists (38%), and Reformists (28%). Respondents from the US/Canada, active reviewers, top-5 reviewers, and editors are more likely to be classified as Traditionalists, while female respondents are less likely to be.

These attitudes could serve as inputs into journal decision-making in two ways. First, they signal which policies are ripe for implementation (e.g., sharing reports) and which might provoke backlash (e.g., referee identifiability). Second, they may proxy for beliefs about policy efficacy, which could help journals identify policies in need of further experimentation (e.g., double-blind anonymity).

Our paper complements recent surveys on peer review that have been conducted in cross-disciplinary settings (Publishing Research Consortium, 2016; Ross-Hellauer et al., 2017) and within economics (Altonji et al., 2025). Compared to the cross-disciplinary surveys, we cover ground especially relevant to journals in economics and take an economic perspective on issues common across disciplines. This distinction is relevant because findings from other disciplines may not generalize to economics. Economics is a relatively small discipline[1] and the effects of identifiability may differ when networks are small. Additionally, peer review in economics features long publication lags (Hadavand et al., 2024), which incentivizes authors to disseminate their preprints widely, thereby complicating anonymity policies. Finally, economics is a social science, which may entail more subjectivity in how we evaluate research findings and imply a greater need for policies that protect the ability of referees to dissent. As compared to Altonji et al. (2025), who survey

[1]For example, the average top-5 journal in economics published 241 articles in 2019-2021, compared to an average of 1,718 articles at top medicine journals in the same timeframe (namely, *The Journal of the American Medical Association*, *The Lancet*, and *The New England Journal of Medicine*). These patterns hold when looking at alternative measures of journal reach.

economists from all fields, we focus on the views of experimental/behavioral economists, whose attitudes may be more relevant to the readership of this journal. Moreover, we investigate several policies that they do not, including referee identifiability and the disclosure of review histories.

Our efforts are divided into six sections. We introduce our survey design and dataset in Section 2. Section 3 features a conceptual framework that formalizes how journals may reason about policy adoption. Next, we explore policies that affect the identifiability of stakeholders (Section 4) and open communication in peer review (Section 5). Section 6 investigates potential heterogeneity and clustering in participant responses. Finally, Section 7 discusses the limitations of our study and possible steps forward.

2 Survey on peer review

We conducted an anonymous survey of economists between July 2020 and January 2021. Researchers could participate if, over the prior two years, they had (i) written at least one referee report and (ii) received reports on at least one journal submission. We inquired about their experiences with the system from their dual perspectives as authors and reviewers, their opinions on its current performance, and their attitudes towards certain proposals for reform.[2] The full questionnaire is in Appendix C and the dataset is on our OSF page (`https://osf.io/eczkv/`).

This paper focuses on respondents' attitudes about eight proposed policies. For each policy, respondents indicated either how favorable they are or how useful they find it for improving referee reports on a 1-5 Likert scale. The policies include publishing referee reports and author responses (either anonymously or signed), sharing reports between reviewers, de-anonymizing senior referees and associate editors, implementing double-blind review, and allowing authors to oppose the assignment of specific reviewers or to appeal manuscript rejections. When relevant, we also report results from other parts of the survey, including perceptions of referee report quality and conflicts of interest.

Our recruitment strategy (detailed in Appendix A.1) leveraged direct emails, advertising through professional networks (e.g., CESifo, CEPR), discussion forum posts (e.g., ESA), and social media. The first wave of emails (July-October 2020) targeted experimental/behavioral economists, yielding 606 responses from 1,802 emails (34%). The second wave (November 2020-January 2021) expanded to other subfields, yielding 269 responses from 3,618 emails (7%). In total, we obtained 1,459 complete responses. Given the interests of this journal's readership, we restrict our presentation of the data to the experimental/behavioral subsample ($N = 802$, 54% of respondents).

[2] We block-randomized the order of the author and reviewer question blocks, but found no evidence of order effects in the responses.

Basic descriptive statistics for this subsample are presented in Table A.3. To assess potential selection bias, we compared the characteristics of this subsample to those of 2020 ESA members (Table A.4) and those of our full sample to the weighted sample in Andre and Falk (2021) and the full sample in Altonji et al. (2025) (Appendix A.3). Relative to these benchmarks, we over-sample researchers in Europe and, in the full sample, we also over-sample experimental/behavioral economists.

3 Conceptual framework

A natural objective for journals is to maximize the expected quality of the papers they publish (Card et al., 2020). Consider a journal that receives a manuscript submission with unobserved quality $q \sim \mathcal{N}(\bar{q}, \sigma_q^2)$. The journal cannot observe q directly; instead, it assigns the paper to a representative reviewer who receives a private signal s:

$$s = q + b(r, t) + \varepsilon,$$

where $b(r, t)$ is a bias term dependent on the author's reputation ($r \in \mathbb{R}$) and the reviewer's taste ($t \in \mathbb{R}$). $\varepsilon \sim \mathcal{N}(0, \sigma_\varepsilon^2(e))$ is an error term. $\frac{\partial b(r,t)}{\partial r} > 0$ implies more favorable reviews for influential authors due to, e.g., status bias (Huber et al., 2022) or expected reciprocity/retaliation. The parameter t represents a reviewer's perception of a manuscript that is related to factors other than r or q, e.g., personal relationships, conflicts of interest, and/or idiosyncratic preferences. The variance of the noise depends on reviewer effort $e \geq 0$, with $\frac{\partial \sigma_\varepsilon^2(e)}{\partial e} < 0$. Effort also improves the final quality of the published paper via revisions, i.e.:

$$q^{\text{published}} = q + \Delta(e), \quad \text{with } \Delta'(e) > 0.$$

Effort is costly, but referees may choose to exert positive effort due to the potential for reputational gain:

$$U = -c(e) + \eta e,$$

where $c(e)$ is increasing and convex and η captures the salience of reputational gains. Each reviewer has a reservation utility below which they would reject the request; in these cases, the journal will rely on the signal and suggested revisions of an alternative reviewer. Critically, η may depend on the journal's policy regime, e.g., referee identifiability. The journal learns about the signal s and must form a posterior belief over q. If the journal is myopic about $b(r, t)$, it treats s as follows:

$$s = q + \varepsilon', \text{with } \varepsilon' \sim \mathcal{N}(0, \sigma_s^2) \text{ and } \sigma_s^2 = \sigma_\varepsilon^2(e) + \sigma_{b(r,t)}^2$$

The journal's posterior belief about q is therefore:

$$\mathbb{E}[q \mid s] = \lambda s + (1 - \lambda)\bar{q}, \quad \text{where } \lambda = \frac{\sigma_q^2}{\sigma_q^2 + \sigma_s^2}.$$

The journal offers an R&R if $E[q^{published} \mid s] = E[q \mid s] + \Delta(e)$ exceeds a publication threshold τ (accounting for space constraints). Both Type I (accepted despite $q^{\text{published}} < \tau$) and Type II (rejected despite $q^{\text{published}} > \tau$) errors are possible. We use this framework throughout the article to discuss policy adoption.

4 Identifiability

Peer-review systems differ in terms of *identifiability*. Single-blind review, where authors are blinded to reviewer identities, is the norm in economics (Table 1), but other possibilities include double-blind review (blinding both authors and referees) and open identifiability (COPE Council, 2017a). This section considers various modifications to the timing and conditions of identity revelation.

4.1 Author identifiability

The case for double-blind review. Single-blind review is currently ubiquitous in economics, but this has not always been the case. In fact, the *American Economic Review* (*AER*) and the *Quarterly Journal of Economics* (*QJE*) only abandoned double anonymity 10-20 years ago (Hengel, 2022). Furthermore, some prominent journals that publish research in economics or psychology continue to use it, including *Management Science*, *Economic Inquiry*, and *Psychological Bulletin* (Table A.6).[3]

Double anonymity, if implemented effectively, protects against identity-based discrimination, i.e., reviewers favoring prominent authors due to status bias (Huber et al., 2022), taste-based discrimination, or statistical discrimination (inferring quality q from author reputation r). As such, we expect heterogeneous effects: double anonymity should decrease the frequency of type I errors for low-q papers from high-r authors and type II errors for high-q papers from low-r authors.

Scope for enabling double-blind review. Our respondents' attitudes towards double-blind review are divided: 39% view it favorably (rating ≥ 4) and 46% unfavorably (rating ≤ 2).[4] The average rating is 2.92 out of 5 ($p = 0.59$ against 3; see Figure 1). Qualitative responses reveal concerns about reviewer objectivity, with "double" and "blind" appearing frequently in comments related to transparency (Figure B.6).[5]

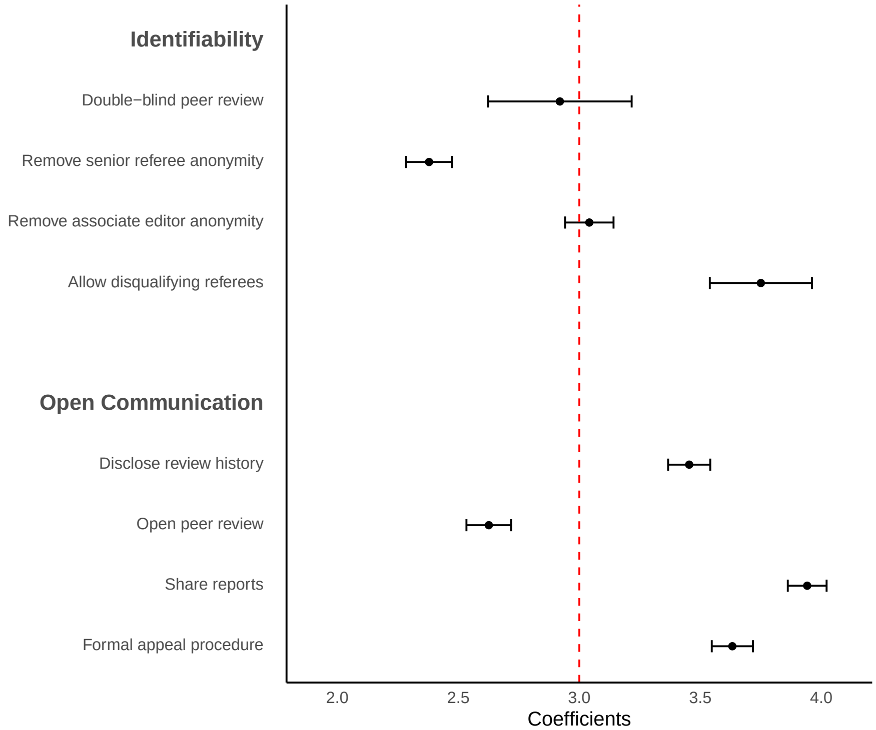
These mixed views appear in line with existing empirical evidence on double-blind review, with some studies finding bias reduction and others reporting null effects (Blank, 1991; Laband and Piette, 1994;

[3] Another possibility is a "triple-blind" system with blinded editors (Jung et al., 2017), as done by some philosophy journals like *Philosophical Review* (Table A.6), but this is more difficult to implement and prevents editors from considering referee conflicts of interests.

[4] The question on double-blind review received only 112 responses, as it was introduced in a later survey wave.

[5] A sizable share of respondents (268/802, 33%) left at least one comment about peer-review policies, but those who select into commenting are unlikely to be representative. Out of all 506 comments, 113 (22%) discuss transparency-related policies (Figure B.6).

Figure 1: Mean response relative to the midpoint value of 3



Notes: This figure plots the means and 95% confidence intervals of the respondents' ratings (1-5) for each of the main eight policies we discuss in the paper. The number of observations is $N = 802$ for all questions except those on double-blind peer review and disqualifying referees, which have $N = 112$ respondents each.

Snodgrass, 2006; Tomkins et al., 2017; Kolev et al., 2019; Ersoy and Pate, 2023). This heterogeneity could relate to field- and time-specific factors that affect the feasibility of anonymizing authors. Anonymity is likely difficult to preserve in small disciplines where authors disseminate preprints widely, like economics, especially in the age of search engines (Goldberg, 2012). Despite these concerns, Altonji et al. (2025) recommend that journals attempt to implement double-blind review, since it is fairly costless and ideal in principle. One possible implementation could be an opt-in model similar to *Nature* (Table 1) and *Nature Human Behaviour* (Table A.6). While authors who opt in may signal low r, thereby undermining potential benefits, the evidence about this policy remains limited and experimentation could be valuable.

4.2 Referee and editor identifiability

The case for open identifiability. Instead of keeping key stakeholders anonymous, one could consider the opposite. In economics, the identities of referees and associate editors are generally concealed to authors and readers, while handling editors are known to the authors and sometimes publicly revealed (Table 1).

However, referee identifiability is becoming increasingly common in other fields (Wolfram et al., 2020),[6] which could make an examination of this policy worthwhile.

Identifiability is likely to increase the scrutiny faced by referees and editors, as authors can link reports to identities, and the research community may view identified referees and editors as offering "seals of approval" to manuscripts. The implications of this heightened scrutiny are ambiguous. Bias could increase if referees become more vulnerable to retaliation, favor-swapping, and social pressure. If so, this would raise the likelihood of type I errors for low-q papers from high-r authors. At the same time, greater scrutiny could enhance the salience of reputational benefits from reviewing η and thus increase effort e. This could improve review quality, yielding more precise signals $\sigma_\varepsilon^2(e)$, more useful revisions $\Delta(e)$, and fewer type I and type II errors. Low-quality reports are a common complaint under the status quo (Silbiger and Stubler, 2019).[7] Publicly identifying referees alongside manuscripts could also help referees earn credit for peer-review contributions in tenure, promotion, and hiring decisions, and allow the community to observe the type I error rates of editors and referees. However, this visibility might make editors and referees more risk averse, leading them to demand more extensive revisions or to shy away from bold research. Finally, identifiability could trigger selection effects if some referees prefer to decline review requests rather than be named, potentially altering the taste t or precision $\sigma_\varepsilon^2(e)$ of those who opt in.

Scope for increasing identifiability. Respondents are generally skeptical about disclosing the identities of senior referees: only 23% consider it useful, while 60% do not. The average rating is 2.38 ($p < 0.001$ against 3; see Figure 1). Views on associate editor anonymity are more divided, with roughly equal shares finding disclosure useful (42%) vs. not useful (40%). The average rating is 3.04 ($p = 0.42$ against 3). Overall, attitudes towards referee identifiability are more skeptical than those reported in other surveys (Publishing Research Consortium, 2016; Ross-Hellauer et al., 2017).

The empirical evidence on the effects of identifiability is generally mixed. In terms of bias, McNutt et al. (1990), Walsh et al. (2000), and Fox (2021) find that identified or voluntary signers tend to give more favorable recommendations, though Van Rooyen et al. (1999) find no differences. The impact on report quality is similarly inconclusive: Walsh et al. (2000) find that identifiability increases effort (time spent) as well as the politeness and quality of reports, but Van Rooyen et al. (1999) and Vinther et al. (2012) find no significant effects. Non-experimental evidence from McNutt et al. (1990) suggests that voluntarily signed reports are more constructive, courteous, and fair. Finally, Van Rooyen et al. (1999) report that referees

[6] Prominent adopters include *The BMJ* and journals in the *Frontiers* family, including *Frontiers Behavioral Economics* and *Frontiers Environmental Economics* under certain conditions (Table 1).

[7] Our survey respondents are moderately satisfied with the reports they receive: on average, they judge 42% to be high quality and 27% to be low quality. Unsatisfactory reports most often contain "*inaccurate statements about what the paper does*" (76% of respondents; Figure B.1), "*vague and unconstructive comments*" (67%), and either "*an aggressive tone*" or "*personal insults*" (42% select at least one of these).

are less likely to accept review invitations under open identifiability, and Fox (2021) find significant (though non-causal) differences in the demographic characteristics of signers versus non-signers.

Alternative or complementary approaches. Given respondents' negative views on full identifiability, we considered alternative policies. One option is to allow referees to opt in to revealing their identity, as practiced by *Nature* (Table 1) and *Nature Human Behaviour* (Table A.6). Referees could use this as a commitment device to produce higher-quality reports and it might help shift norms over time, though concerns about favor trading would likely persist.

Another option is for journals to periodically acknowledge the contributions of their referees (Tennant et al., 2017), as some economics journals already do (Table 1). This would raise the visibility of refereeing and allow for the assessment of the diversity of referee pools. A variation of this policy, in which referee turnaround times were also published, was tested experimentally by Chetty et al. (2014). The main effect, relative to a no-visibility group, was to lower the acceptance rate of review requests.

We also consider whether exposing unrecorded conflicts of interest, a purported benefit of identifiability (Benos et al., 2007), can be achieved without piercing anonymity. Conflicts can create either positive or negative bias, depending on whether they stem from personal relationships, competing papers, or ideological differences. Regarding positive bias, network proximity and social ties are predictive of positive recommendations and decisions (Brogaard et al., 2014; Colussi, 2018; Carrell et al., 2024). While this may partly reflect other factors, such as lower search costs, fairness concerns remain (Altonji et al., 2025). Among our respondents, 16% reported rejecting or considering rejecting a referee request due to a conflict over the prior two years. We also asked them about "*people refereeing papers by co-authors or friends*." Most answered either "*this should never happen*" (40%) or "*this should happen as little as possible but cannot be avoided sometimes*" (44%). The latter answer may reflect a potential trade-off between bias $b(r, t)$ and variance $\sigma_{\varepsilon}^2(e)$: the most knowledgeable referees are often connected to authors working in the same area. Altonji et al. (2025) propose several policies to help navigate this trade-off, including requiring reviewers and authors to disclose potential conflicts and offering clearer guidelines about what constitutes a conflict. Nine of the ten journals listed in Table 1 have conflict policies for editors, while six have them for referees.

To minimize negative bias from conflicts, one idea is to give authors the option to proactively oppose the appointment of certain referees. This idea has broad support: 61% of respondents report favorable attitudes, 12% report unfavorable ones, and the average response is 3.75 ($p < 0.001$ against 3, Figure 1). Attitudes are similarly favorable in Altonji et al. (2025). While authors may attempt to use this policy strategically (Moore et al., 2011; Teixeira da Silva and Alkhatib, 2018), the option would be available to everyone. Moreover, editors may find complaints about certain referees more credible when they are communicated before manuscript decisions, rather than ex-post. This option exists at neither the ESA journals nor the top-5 journals (Table 1).

5 Open communication

We now examine two other dimensions of peer review: the *publication* of peer-review documents and the *mediation* of interactions between stakeholders (COPE Council, 2017a). COPE identifies three publication policies: keeping reports confidential, publishing unsigned reports, and publishing signed reports. For mediation, they distinguish between editor-mediated interactions, open interaction between reviewers, and open interaction between reviewers and authors. Unpublished reports and editor-mediated interactions are uniformly embraced by the top-5 and ESA journals (Table 1). We consider policies that deviate from these norms.

5.1 Publication of peer-review documents and metadata

The case for publishing peer-review data. Most journals keep referee reports and decision letters confidential by default, as sharing them would likely require the informed consent of authors, referees, and editors (COPE Council, 2017b). Yet, some exceptions outside economics exist, including *The BMJ* and *Nature* (Table 1). Journals are also increasingly sharing statistics and metadata, such as average turnaround times.

Publishing peer-review documents is likely to increase the scrutiny faced by reviewers and editors because such materials often contain identifying elements (even if unsigned) and because low-quality reports and letters can harm the reputation of journals. Fully open peer review, i.e., publishing signed reports, would amplify this further by removing any doubts about identities. As discussed previously, the net effect of enhanced scrutiny depends on the relative strength of the effort and bias channels.

Making peer-review documents public (with author responses and prior manuscript versions) could also help readers assess a paper's intrinsic quality q, the informativeness of referee feedback (reflected in $\sigma^2_\varepsilon(e)$ and $b(r,t)$), and the added value of revisions $\Delta(e)$. Beyond individual papers, such documents could shed light on how peer review shapes research by providing stronger evidence on whether $\Delta(e)$ varies with the number of revision rounds or the nature of revision requests (Malički et al., 2022). This may be particularly relevant in experimental economics, where requests for additional experiments can be especially costly.

Scope for increasing data sharing. Our respondents are generally supportive of sharing anonymized referee reports and author responses: 55% hold favorable views, 22% unfavorable views, and the average rating is 3.45 ($p < 0.001$ against 3; Figure 1). However, respondents appear less convinced of the impact of this policy on review quality: only 38% expect it to be useful, while 41% expect otherwise; the average rating is 2.94 ($p = 0.21$ against 3). The divergence between favorability and perceived usefulness - moderate at the individual level (correlation $\rho = 0.59$ between responses) - may reflect the view that publishing these documents is informative but unlikely to change reviewer behavior.

To go one step further, we also measured attitudes towards fully open peer review. Respondents were fairly skeptical, with 50% holding unfavorable attitudes, 27% holding favorable attitudes, and an average response of 2.63 ($p < 0.001$ against 3, Figure 1). Interestingly, attitudes are less positive than those towards publishing unsigned reports, but more positive than towards referee identifiability with confidential reports.

Our respondents' views appear more cautious than those expressed in a cross-disciplinary survey on open peer review (Ross-Hellauer et al., 2017). Cautious attitudes could be expected given the very limited evidence available on the impact of such policies. The two main studies on the topic are Bravo et al. (2019), who observationally examine how publishing unsigned referee reports affects behavior at five journals, and van Rooyen et al. (2010), who randomly informed some referees that their signed reviews might be published online. Bravo et al. (2019) find no overall effect on key outcomes, including willingness to review, time spent, report quality (proxied by objective language), or referee recommendations. However, younger and non-academic referees increased their willingness to review, showed greater objectivity, and gave more positive recommendations, suggesting that less influential referees may be more sensitive to scrutiny. Results differ somewhat in van Rooyen et al. (2010), where treated referees spent more time on reports and produced higher-quality reviews for accepted papers, though they were no more likely to recommend acceptance. Suggestively, Zong et al. (2020) find that papers with voluntarily disclosed review histories are cited more often.

Alternative or complementary approaches. Short of sharing full review histories, journals could publish summaries of how manuscripts changed from submission to publication, as done by *F1000Research* (Table A.6). This would provide standardized, low-burden evidence on the effects of peer review. As proposed by Altonji et al. (2025), journals could also standardize how they report metadata, such as turnaround times and acceptance rates, to enable comparisons across journals. More granular information, such as submission dates or the number of revision rounds, could further enhance transparency, promote accountability, and help authors make more informed submission decisions without compromising confidentiality. Finally, Altonji et al. (2025) suggest that journals could make author contribution statements mandatory for papers with many authors, as done in other disciplines; this would allow all readers, including those on tenure, hiring, and promotion committees, to understand the distribution of work and the contributions of specific co-authors.

5.2 Open channels of communication

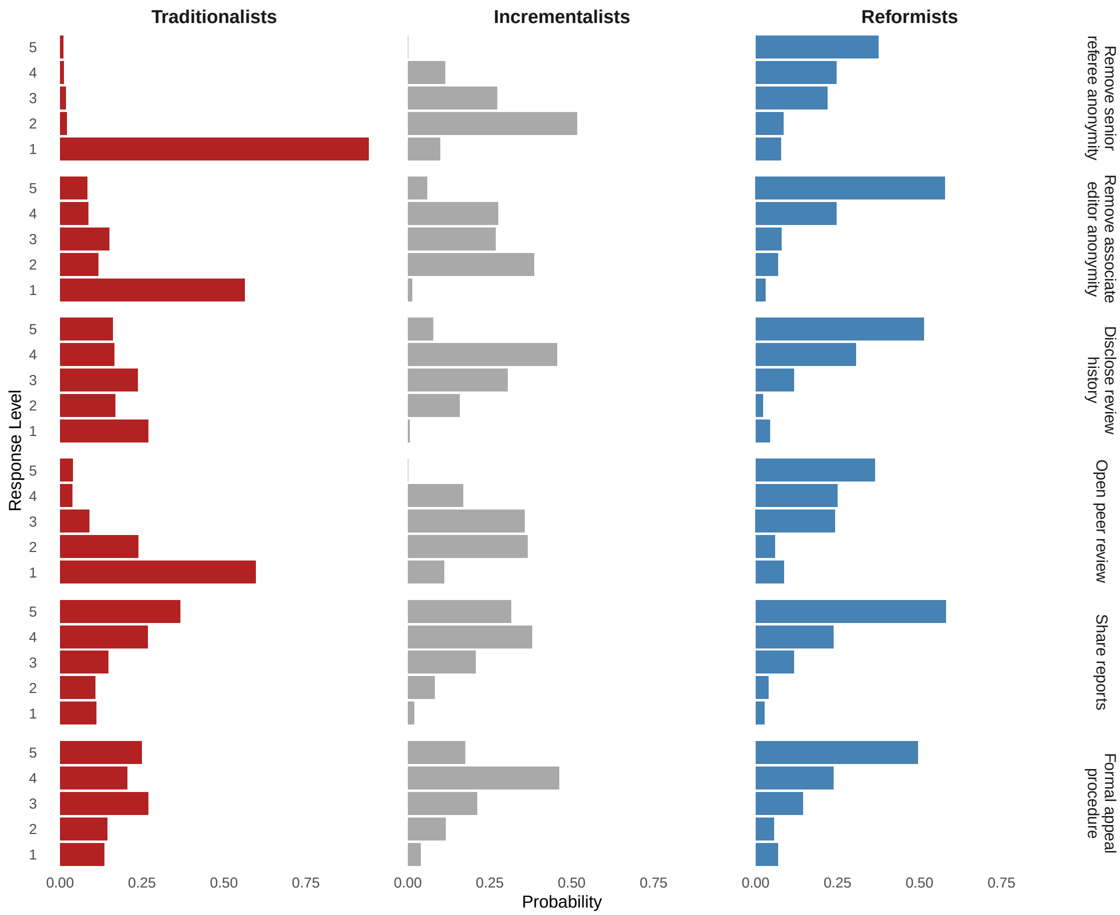
The case for opening communication. Interactions between stakeholders during the review process in economics tend to be limited and asynchronous. In particular, editors interact directly with authors and reviewers in sequential stages and mediate interactions between these stakeholders via referee reports and author responses. As such, under the status quo, the editor is responsible for aggregating the demands of reviewers and giving direction to authors. Such efforts appear essential, as a near majority of respondents (46%) complained about "*unrealistic*" and/or "*inconsistent*" demands from reviewers. However, many of our respondents also expressed discontent regarding the extent of editorial direction (Charness et al., 2022) and the word "editor" appeared frequently in their comments, as shown in Figure B.5. In principle, a more directed and dynamic review process could allow stakeholders to discuss and resolve these issues promptly. This could also substantially speed up turnaround times, especially if these discussions replace multi-month revision rounds, an issue that distinguishes economics from other disciplines (Hamermesh, 1994; Hadavand et al., 2024). These benefits must be balanced against communication costs, as a more interactive review process might require more intense effort from editors and referees at specific times. In addition, increasing the volume of interactions makes de-anonymization more likely and could create opportunities for well-connected authors to apply pressure on reviewers.

Scope for increasing communication channels. The most ambitious version of increased communication would allow real-time interactions between authors and referees, as practiced by *Frontiers* (Table 1). Very few journals currently use this format, and empirical evidence on mediation policies remains limited (Ross-Hellauer et al., 2017), making it unlikely to be adopted in disciplines with more conservative peer-review practices, such as economics.

Short of a fully interactive system, journals could open new channels between selected stakeholders. One option is to establish an official procedure for authors to respond to editors and referees after receiving a rejection. This would allow authors to plead their case without imposing significant additional work on editors or referees in most cases. Formal appeals are standard in computer science conferences (Shah, 2023) but are not always available in economics (Table 1). Anecdotal evidence suggests that informal appeals occur in practice; if such appeals disproportionately favor well-connected authors, a formal procedure could help create a more level playing field. We asked respondents for their views on such a policy: over 60% were favorable, 19% were unfavorable, and the average response was 3.63 ($p < 0.001$ against 3; Figure 1). Support was similar among editors (-0.01, $p = 0.85$) but somewhat lower among active reviewers (-0.10, $p < 0.001$).

Another option is to ask authors to submit a revision proposal to editors and referees before proceeding with an R&R. This could clarify key issues before costly revisions are undertaken and reduce wasted effort

Figure 2: LCA classification of responses



Notes: This figure shows the results of a Latent Class Analysis (LCA), which aims to identify clusters of responses to six survey questions ($N = 802$ for each question). Responses to the questions on "disqualifying referees" and "double-blind peer review" (both $N = 112$) are excluded since the LCA requires non-missing values for all respondents and questions. The number of classes was chosen to minimize the Bayesian information criterion. There are 18 subplots in the figure, each of which shows the probability (bottom axis) that an individual in that class (top axis) would give a specific response (left axis) to a given question (right axis). Our chosen names for each class can be seen on the top axis.

on revising manuscripts that are ultimately rejected. The downside is the additional upfront work required.

Finally, journals could share reports between reviewers more systematically. This policy is popular among respondents: 71% find it useful and 13% do not, with an average response of 3.9 ($p < 0.001$ against 3; Figure 1). This is typically done ex post but could also occur at an intermediate stage to help referees with their evaluations. Some editors, however, may prefer to preserve signal independence (Lorenz et al., 2011).

6 Evaluating policies jointly

The previous sections examined support for each policy separately. To identify possible complementarities, we now consider whether support for transparency in one dimension predicts support in others.

Correlations between respondents' support for different policies are generally weak, with most below 0.3 (Figure B.2). The strongest is between de-anonymizing associate editors and senior referees ($\rho = 0.68$). Moderate correlations also appear between support for fully open peer review and both de-anonymizing senior referees ($\rho = 0.58$) and disclosing review histories ($\rho = 0.54$). No other correlation exceeds $\rho = 0.50$.

Since correlations only capture linear, pairwise relationships, we also use latent class analysis (LCA) to identify distinct respondent types with similar attitudes. Using the six questions answered by the full sample, we group respondents based on their rating patterns, selecting the number of classes using the Bayesian Information Criterion. As shown in Figure 2, the LCA identifies three groups differing in their openness to reform. The first group (red), which we label *Traditionalists*, generally favors the status quo and holds the most negative views on open peer review. They have the highest likelihood of giving each policy a rating of 1. At the other end, the third group (blue), the *Reformists*, shows the highest probability of rating each policy as 5. In between, the second group (gray), the *Incrementalists*, gives responses closer to 3 for each question. No group forms a majority: 38% are Incrementalists, 33% are Traditionalists, and 28% are Reformists (Figure B.3).

To explore potential heterogeneity, we regressed indicators for class membership on a range of demographic characteristics (Figure 3).[8] Respondents from the US/Canada, editors, top-5 reviewers, and active reviewers, possible "gatekeepers" of the system, are more likely to be classified as Traditionalists, while female respondents are less likely. Editors, top-5 reviewers, and active reviewers are less likely to be classified as Reformists. No other significant differences emerge.[9] This classification exercise reveals that the lack of consensus on many policies may reflect the existence of distinct factions in the transparency debate.

Our heterogeneity findings align with recent surveys suggesting that seniority is negatively associated with support for certain open science practices, such as pre-analysis plans (Ross-Hellauer et al., 2017; Logg and Dorison, 2021; Spitzer and Mueller, 2023; Imai et al., 2025). For example, Imai et al. (2025) find that full professors are less favorable towards pre-analysis plans, policies recommending or mandating their use, registered reports, and results-blind review. By contrast, Ferguson et al. (2023) find no difference in support for open science practices between published authors and PhD students.

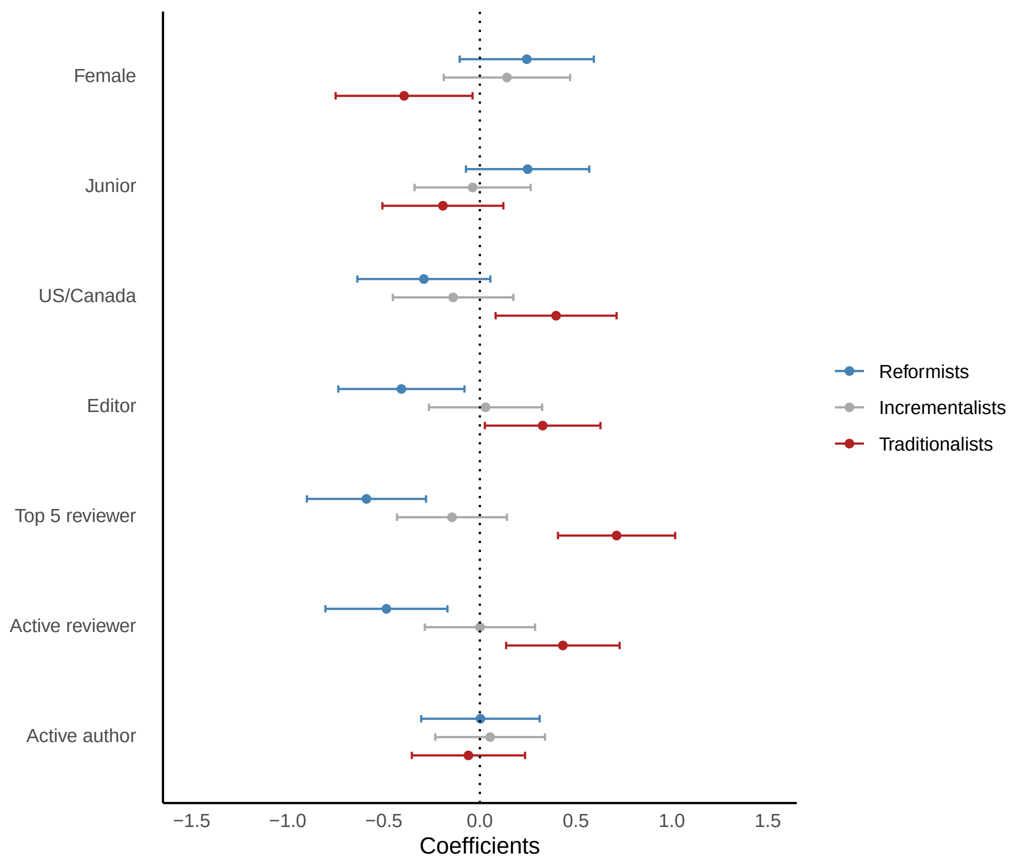
7 Looking forward

In this article, we investigated our respondents' attitudes towards transparency reforms in peer review. Overall, we find some degree of openness towards making changes, but views differ based on the exact policy considered and respondent characteristics. Starting with identifiability, there is no clear majority in favor of

[8] For heterogeneity analysis at the individual policy level, see Table B.1.

[9] The share of respondents within each class who belong to each demographic group is shown in Figure B.4.

Figure 3: Demographic predictors of LCA classification



Notes: This figure plots point estimates and 95% confidence intervals for potential demographic predictors of class membership. Each coefficient was obtained from a separate linear probability model, regressing class membership on particular demographic characteristic (left axis).

changing the status quo for senior referees, associate editors, or authors, though opinions about the latter two are more ambivalent. In contrast, there is strong support for allowing authors to oppose the assignment of specific reviewers. On open communication, respondents express broad support for publishing unsigned referee reports and author responses, sharing reports among reviewers, and establishing a formal appeal process, while remaining skeptical of publishing signed reports. Looking across policies, we identify three respondent types: *Traditionalists* (33%), *Incrementalists* (38%), and *Reformists* (28%). Membership in the Traditionalist class is somewhat predicted by seniority (e.g., editor status, active reviewing) and network centrality (US/Canada) and negatively predicted by whether a respondent is female.

Our findings come with three key policy implications. First, it is likely that a handful of policies are already possible to implement with minimal risk of backlash, including sharing reports between reviewers and allowing author appeals. Second, given possible heterogenous effects and divided opinions about policies like anonymity for authors, some degree of horizontal differentiation between journals may make sense. For example, *Econometrica* recently opened an additional channel for manuscript readers to engage in post-publication discussion about papers (Table A.6). Policies like these allow stakeholders to sort into journals whose transparency norms are consistent with their preferences and create data that helps other journals make informed decisions about policy adoption. Third, given that respondent views differ substantially based on demographic characteristics, recruiting diverse editorial boards could help ensure that policy adoption decisions are made with input from multiple perspectives.

Our findings also come with caveats. First, even through the lens of the single objective function that we examine, most policies have ambiguous effects on the quality of peer review due to competing forces. Furthermore, different journals likely have different objective functions, with some placing more weight on the experiences of authors (e.g., ensuring fast and fair decisions) and others prioritizing the interests of referees, editors, and readers. These factors may help explain the lack of consensus among our respondents on some policies. Second, while we discuss a broad range of policies, we necessarily do not cover every topic. Certain omitted topics, like the role of large language models in peer review, have received a great deal of attention recently (Altonji et al., 2025; Rao et al., 2025). Third, among the policies that we do consider, our survey results focus on measuring attitudes rather than determinants of these attitudes. Relatedly, our elicitations are unincentivized, subject to measurement error, and might depend on whether respondents answer from their perspective as an author, referee, reader, or editor.[10] Finally, we acknowledge limitations in how actionable our findings are, given the minimal causal evidence that exists to assist journals with policy adoption. To address this, we encourage journals and other institutions to run their own experiments and surveys in a systematic manner, as outlined by Bendiscioli et al. (2022).

This further research could take many directions. In particular, future surveys could investigate how beliefs about policy impact map into overall policy support, measure support for alternative policies, and track how views evolve over time. Additional experimental studies, particularly within economics, would be useful for filling the current gap in causal evidence. Since real-world trials are difficult to implement, lab or online experiments that simulate peer review could serve as a first step. Studies of opt-in policies could also shed light on take-up rates and help shift norms over time.

[10]For what it is worth, regarding our unincentivized elicitation, some papers suggest that the effect of incentives on respondent behavior is minimal, e.g., Enke et al. (2023). Regarding framing effects, we find no evidence that policy ratings differ based on whether the author or reviewer question block appeared first.

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A Data discussions

This appendix is devoted to explaining aspects of our data collection and sample in greater detail and presenting additional figures and tables.

A.1 Survey recruitment

To increase participation in the survey, we conducted multiple stages of recruitment within different communities of academic economists. A timeline and summary of these efforts can be found in Table A.1. The first part (Wave 1) lasted from July 2020 to October 2020. In this phase, we targeted groups of experimental/behavioral economists. An initial pilot study was sent to a select group in order to gather feedback on the content and structure of the survey. After that, a link to the survey was posted on the Economic Science Association (ESA) discussion forum. Next, we created a database of email addresses of experimental/behavioral economists in order to reach a larger group of potential respondents (mail merge 1). Email addresses in the database came from a wide variety of sources, including lists of experimental/behavioral economists on the RePEc database and participation lists from various conferences and seminars, i.e., the ESA conference, the Early-Career Behavioral Economics Conference (ECBE), and the Stanford Institute for Theoretical Economics conference (SITE). A few emails were also added individually. The entire database was sent an initial email in early August, which was followed by a reminder email in late September, sent only to those who had not provided their email address after taking the survey (i.e., in order to be considered for the prize drawing). We sent emails out to 1,802 researchers, from whom we received 606 complete or partially complete responses (34%). A separate but similar email was also sent to participants in the Virtual East Asia Experimental and Behavioral Seminar (VEAEBES).

The second part (Wave 2) was conducted from November 2020 to January 2021. In this stage, we shifted our efforts to recruiting economists from outside of experimental/behavioral economics. We did this by reaching out to communities of economists that are not specific to any subfield, as well as conducting efforts targeted at some particular subfields. Posts on the European Economic Association (EEA) website and Twitter feed advertised the survey to general groups of economists. Emails sent to the CESifo and CEPR networks targeted similarly varied groups. Subfield-specific outreach efforts included a post on the Decision Theory (DT) forum and emails sent to Health Economics at Lancaster (HEAL) seminar series members. Finally, we constructed another database of email addresses targeted at non-experimental/behavioral economists, with a particular emphasis on reaching out to underrepresented fields like macroeconomics (mail merge 2). The database was partly constructed with participant lists of conferences hosted by various organizations, including the Society for Economic Dynamics (SED), the American Economic Association/Allied

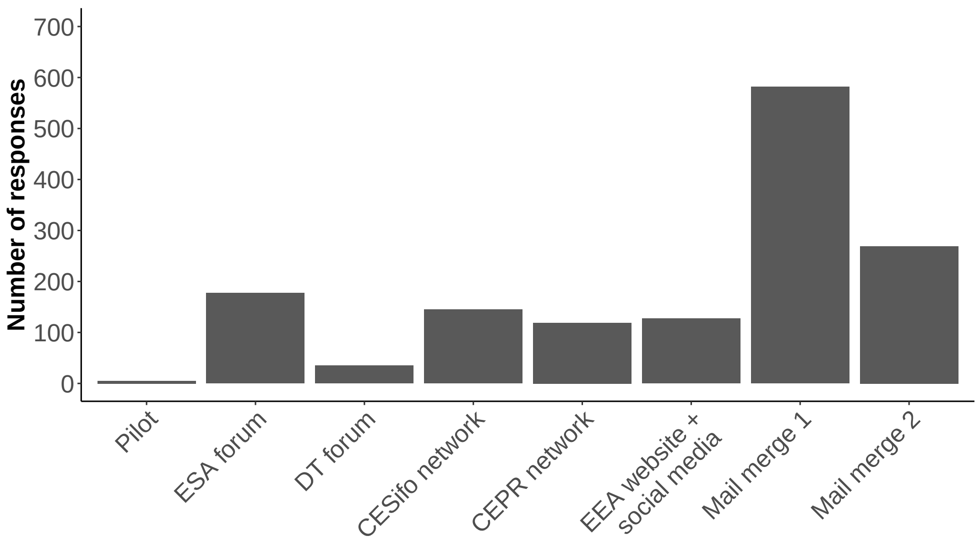
Social Science Associations (AEA/ASSA), the Society for Judgment and Decision Making (SJDM), and the Society for the Advancement of Economic Theory (SAET). We also included contact details collected from the NBER database and added some emails individually. The entire email database received a survey request in mid-December, followed by a reminder email in mid-January (once again to those we could not confirm took the survey). We sent emails out to 3,618 researchers, from whom we received 269 responses (7%). Informal recruitment efforts took place throughout the entire recruitment period, including via individual emails and social media posts sharing the survey link.

As mentioned elsewhere, 1,497 (1,459) individuals at least partially (fully) responded to our recruitment efforts. The median response time for fully completed surveys was 15.5 minutes. Most respondents were recruited from the two mail merges, from which we received 875 completed or partially completed responses (58% of our sample). Four other recruitment channels garnered >100 completed responses each (Figure A.1).[11] Characteristics of the sample broken down by recruitment channel can be found in Table A.2. Some clear demographic differences are worth noting. First, the CESifo and CEPR channels have particularly high percentages of respondents over 50 (44% and 39%, respectively), respondents who are full professors (57% and 59%), and respondents with editorial experience (50% and 56%). Additionally, the percentage of US/Canada-based respondents from mail merge 2 (63%) is much higher than the other channels, which feature more Europe-based researchers. Finally, while all channels have a fairly high percentage of researchers who have refereed for top-5 journals, this percentage is particularly high in the CEPR and mail merge 2 channels (84% and 71%, respectively).

After completing our primary analysis of the survey data, we sent out a follow-up survey in February 2022 ($N = 117$) to clarify our interpretation of the initial results and gather further evidence. Our additional inquiries included questions on what respondents consider to be reasonable report-writing activity, whether they feel pressured to write more referee reports due to publication concerns around their own manuscripts, and the percentage of their submissions from 2020-2021 that were desk rejected (28%). These results were included in our original report, but are excluded from the present article. Compared to the original survey, the follow-up survey sampled relatively few full (34%) and assistant (19%) professors, and relatively many postdoc/PhD candidates (19%). 33% of respondents reported that they are currently editors.

[11] A recruitment channel is based on the survey link used. Some survey links were used in multiple methods of recruitment; these are considered to be one recruitment channel.

Figure A.1: Distribution of responses across recruitment channels



Notes: This figure only includes respondents who fully completed the survey. $N = 1,459$.

Table A.1: Recruitment strategy summary

Wave	Date	Targeted group	Recruitment channel (survey link)
Wave 1 (Experimental/behavioral)	Early July 2020	Selected group for initial feedback	Pilot (individual emails)
	16 July 2020	ESA forum	ESA forum
	8 August 2020	RePEc/ESA/AEA-ASSA/ECBE/SITE	Mail merge 1
	18 September 2020	VEABES	Mail merge 1
Wave 2 (All fields)	13 November 2020	EEA	EEA website + social media
	15 November 2020	DT forum	DT forum
	24 November 2020	CESifo	CESifo network
	26 November 2020	CEPR	CEPR network
	7 December 2020	HEAL	EEA website + social media
	16 December 2020	NBER/SAET/SED/AEA-ASSA/SJDM	Mail merge 2
Informal outreach	Sporadically	Personal emails	EEA website + social media[a]
	Sporadically	Social media	EEA website + social media

Notes: See previous page for more information about the meaning of the various acronyms. ***a:*** Some personal emails were sent using different survey links, but the majority used the link for "EEA website + social media."

Table A.2: Characteristics across recruitment channels[a]

Characteristic	ESA forum	CESifo	CEPR	EEA/social media	Mail merge 1	Mail merge 2
Demographics						
Female	28%	18%	28%	29%	24%	26%
Age:						
Under 40	55%	30%	27%	51%	40%	49%
40–49	28%	26%	34%	36%	38%	26%
50–59	11%	26%	22%	10%	15%	18%
60 and over	6%	18%	17%	4%	7%	10%
Location:						
US/Canada	32%	27%	23%	29%	31%	63%
Europe	58%	69%	74%	62%	54%	31%
Asia/Oceania	7%	3%	3%	8%	14%	5%
Other countries	3%	1%	0%	2%	2%	2%
Position						
Full professor	23%	57%	59%	25%	39%	37%
Associate professor	26%	14%	22%	23%	26%	17%
Assistant professor	27%	16%	12%	29%	26%	34%
Postdoc/PhD candidate	18%	5%	0%	15%	5%	7%
Other position	7%	8%	8%	7%	4%	5%
Experience						
Editorial experience	29%	50%	56%	30%	38%	41%
Average number of publications[b]	21	40	27	25	28	20
Referee for top-5 journals	46%	55%	84%	43%	58%	71%
N[c]	190	145	119	128	606	269

Notes: ***a:*** This table only looks at the recruitment channels (i.e., survey links) that received > 100 partially- or fully-completed responses (= 97% of the total sample). ***b:*** Full range used (no top coding). ***c:*** These sample sizes refer to all partially- or fully-completed surveys for each recruitment channel. For the individual statistics, sample sizes may differ from the stated N as unanswered questions and "Prefer not to say" responses were removed from these calculations.

A.2 Sample descriptive statistics

Table A.3: Descriptive statistics for the main dimensions of heterogeneity

Variable	N	Share
Female	196	24%
Junior	268	33%
US/Canada	239	30%
Editor	297	37%
Top-5 reviewer	441	55%
Active reviewer	350	44%
Active author	367	46%
N	802	100%

Variable descriptions:

- `Female`: Binary variable = 1 if the respondent selected "Female," with the baseline being the combination of "Male" (71%) + "Prefer not to say" (4%).
- `Junior`: Binary variable = 1 if the respondent selected "PhD candidate" or "Post-doctoral researcher" or "Assistant professor" as their position.
- `US/Canada`: Binary variable = 1 if the respondent selected "United States" or "Canada" as the country in which their job is located.
- `Editor`: Binary variable = 1 if the respondent answered "Yes" to having held an editorial position.
- `Top-5 reviewer`: Binary variable = 1 if the respondent indicated that > 0% of their referee reports had been written for a top-5 journal.
- `Active reviewer`: Binary variable = 1 if the respondent wrote more reports annually than the median respondent in our sub-sample (> 8 reports).
- `Active author`: Binary variable = 1 if the respondent made more submissions over the designated timeframe than the median respondent in our sub-sample (> 6 submissions over two years).

A.3 Sample representativeness

Since there are no comprehensive statistics on the global population of economists, we assess potential selection bias by comparing the characteristics of our sample to statistics from relevant subpopulations and other surveys. We first benchmark our experimental/behavioral subsample against 2020 ESA members

Table A.4: Comparison between experimental/behavioral sample and ESA membership

Categories	**Our sample (%)**	**ESA 2020 members (%)**
Female	24%	38%
Student	9%	26%
Europe	55%	40%
US/Canada	30%	35%
Asia/Oceania	12%	23%
Africa/Other Americas	2%	2%
N	802	994

Notes: ***a:*** The demographic characteristics of ESA 2020 members were obtained directly from the ESA.

(Table A.4) and our full sample against the weighted sample in Andre and Falk (2021) (Table A.5).[12] Relative to these groups, we somewhat under-sample women and over-sample researchers based in Europe. In addition, we significantly over-sample those in experimental/behavioral economics relative to Andre and Falk (2021). While the ESA provides a useful reference point, its membership may not fully represent the broader experimental/behavioral community. For additional context, we also compare our full sample with that from Altonji et al. (2025), though their survey includes limited demographic data; again, we observe an over-representation of European and experimental/behavioral researchers.

[12] Andre and Falk (2021) use a database containing nearly all active economists with EconLit publication data, weighted to reflect the underlying population.

Table A.5: Comparison between full sample and Andre & Falk (2021) benchmarks

Characteristic	Peer-review survey	EconLit population (AF)	Unweighted sample (AF)	Weighted sample (AF)
Demographics				
Female	24%	26%	23%	26%
Age:				
Under 40	43%	-	33%	35%
40-49	32%	-	33%	32%
50-59	16%	-	19%	18%
60 and over	9%	-	16%	16%
Location:				
US/Canada	36%	34%	24%	34%
Europe	54%	40%	54%	41%
Asia/Oceania	8%	21%	17%	21%
Other regions	2%	4%	5%	5%
Field (excl. Exp/Behav)[a]				
Microeconomics	28%	15%	18%	15%
Macroeconomics	13%	31%	24%	30%
Econometrics	9%	4%	3%	3%
Development	8%	7%	8%	8%
Labor	11%	9%	12%	10%
Industrial organization	6%	8%	7%	8%
Public economics	11%	4%	4%	4%
Other fields	15%	22%	23%	23%
Position				
Full professor	38%	-	41%	37%
Associate professor	22%	-	27%	28%
Assistant professor	27%	-	20%	22%
Postdoc/PhD candidate	8%	-	10%	10%
Other position	6%	-	2%	3%
Research output				
Average number of publications	25	17	18	16
N	1,459[b]	53,779	7,794	7,794

Notes: The statistics in the last three columns were either directly taken from Andre and Falk (2021) (AF) or derived for us by Peter Andre. ***a:*** For the field statistics, we removed the "Experimental/Behavioral" selection from our survey data to improve comparability with the Andre & Falk data for the other fields. As such, it is useful to remember that we report a conditional distribution. For example, the microeconomics category, consisting of respondents who selected either applied microeconomics, decision theory, game theory, or microeconomic theory as a field, accounts for 28% of all field selections that were not behavioral or experimental economics ($N = 2,668$ remaining selections). Experimental/Behavioral economics accounts for 33% of the total number of field selections (out of $N = 3,982$ selections made across all fields). ***b:*** The sample size reported for our peer-review survey is the number of completed surveys. However, for our statistics to be comparable with the data in AF, we needed to remove the respondents who selected "Prefer not to say" for `Age`, `Location`, and `Position`. This leads to smaller sample sizes for those variables (with $N = 1,381, 1,392,$ and $1,401$, respectively). For the `Female` statistic, responses of "Prefer not to say" were kept.

Below we elaborate on the definitions of certain variables and note any instances where variables had to be reformulated in order to ensure the comparability of our data with the external data.

- **Location:** From the Andre and Falk (2021) (AF) statistics, we combine the "Asia" and "Australia and

New Zealand" categories to create the "Asia/Oceania" category and we combine the "Latin America" and "Africa" categories to create the "Other regions" category.

- **Field of research:** The field categories from AF are based on the JEL codes:
  - Microeconomics = JEL D (Microeconomics)
  - Macroeconomics = JEL E (Macroeconomics and Monetary Economics) + JEL F (International Economics) + JEL G (Financial Economics)
  - Econometrics = JEL C (Mathematical and Quantitative Methods)
  - Development = JEL O (Growth and Development Economics)
  - Labor = JEL J (Labor and Demographic Economics)
  - Industrial Organization = JEL L (Industrial Organization)
  - Public Economics = JEL H (Public Economics)
  - Other fields = JEL Q (Agriculture and Environmental Economics) + Other fields
- **Position:** The "Full Professor" category combines the AF categories of "Professor" and "Emeritus"; the "Postdoc/PhD" category combines "Post-doc" and "Doctoral student"; and the "Other" category combines "Graduate student" and "Other."
- **Average number of publications:** The number of publications is capped at 200.

A.4 Construction of the journal transparency policies table

The abbreviations used in Table 1 are as follows:

- *Exp Econ* = *Experimental Economics*; *JESA* = *Journal of the Economic Science Association*; *AER* = *American Economic Review*; *ECMA* = *Econometrica*; *JPE* = *Journal of Political Economy*; *QJE* = *Quarterly Journal of Economics*; *REStud* = *Review of Economic Studies*

We made use of a wide range of data sources to collect the data presented in Table 1. We also made several subjective judgments about the best way to code the available information and data. In this section, we provide more information about the construction of this table:

- Our first judgment relates to which journals' transparency policies to include in the table. Due to the significant contribution of the Economic Science Association (ESA) and its membership to our survey results, we include the two journals of the ESA (i.e., *Experimental Economics* and *JESA*). Given their importance to the careers of economists (Heckman and Moktan, 2020), we also include each of the traditional "top-5" journals. For the other disciplines, we selectively chose three journals or journal families in order to highlight a number of unique or innovative policies for discussion.

- The policies in the **Identifiability** section of the table were obtained from a range of sources, which are listed in Table A.6.

  - The ***Blinded Review*** variable indicates whether the referees are blinded to the identity of the author during the review process ("Double") or not. Usually, when this is not the case, referee identities still remain obscured to authors ("Single"). However, in the case of *The BMJ*, author and referee identities are mutually known ("Open"). At *Nature*, authors can opt-in to double-blind review ("Opt-in"). Most journals mention their review policy in their guidelines. The ESA and top-5 journals are uniform in their application of single-blind refereeing, which we (the authors) can confirm through personal experience.

  - The ***Referee Identity Disclosed*** variable indicates whether the journal publicly discloses the identities of the referees who evaluated each manuscript after the review process is complete (✓) or not (–). At *Frontiers*, the identities of referees who recommend publication are disclosed after review is complete and conditional on acceptance. At *Nature*, referee identities are revealed and published alongside the manuscript post-review, as long as both the authors and referees agree to this. This information was obtained by reading journal policies and checking published manuscripts.

- The ***Handling Editor Disclosed*** variable indicates whether the journal publicly discloses the identity of the handling editor(s) who decided to accept each manuscript after the review process is complete (✓) or not (–). This information was obtained by inspecting a selection of articles on each journal website.
- The ***Journal Publishes List of Referees*** variable indicates whether the journal periodically publishes a full list of its referees ("Full"), a partial list ("Partial"), or no list at all ("No"). *QJE* and *REStud* limit their referee list to those who have met a certain threshold of quality/quantity contribution. These lists can usually be found in periodic journal reports or on journal websites.
- The ***Authors Can Nominate Referees*** and ***Authors Can Oppose Referees*** variables indicate whether the journal specifically allows or asks authors to make suggestions to include or exclude specific referees by name for each submission (✓) or not (–), respectively, as part of the regular submission process. This information was obtained by clicking through the submission portal of each journal.
- The ***Conflict-of-Interest Policy for Editors*** and ***Conflict-of-Interest Policy for Reviewers*** variables indicate whether the journal has public conflict-of-interest policies for editors and reviewers (✓) or not (–), respectively. Policies for editors usually state the conditions under which an editor should recuse themselves from handling a manuscript, while those for reviewers typically relate to reporting potential conflicts with the author for consideration by the editor. This information was obtained by reading journal policies.

- The statistics in the **Disclosure** section also come from a wide range of sources (Table A.6).
  - ***Turnaround Time Statistics*** and ***Acceptance/Rejection Statistics*** record whether each journal releases statistics on its turnaround time and its acceptance/rejection rates (✓) or not (–), respectively. This is usually done via a periodic report or on the journal website.
  - The ***Manuscript Received/Decision Dates*** variable indicates whether a journal discloses certain manuscript metadata alongside publications (✓) or not (–), in particular the date that the manuscript was received, the date of first response, the dates that subsequent versions were returned, and/or the acceptance date. This information was obtained by inspecting a selection of articles on each journal website.
  - The ***Public Decision Letters*** variable is an indicator for whether a journal releases editors' decision letters alongside published manuscripts (✓) or not (–). For *The BMJ*, this was verified by inspecting recently published articles. *Nature* states on its peer review page that decision

letters are released "in some cases."

- The ***Public Referee Reports*** variable is an indicator for whether a journal releases referees' reports alongside published manuscripts (✓) or not (–). The ***Signed Public Referee Reports*** is an additional indicator for whether the authors of each report are publicly specified. This was verified by inspecting recently published articles from *The BMJ* and *Nature*. We note once again that *Nature* policies are subject to referee and author consent.
- The ***Prior Manuscript Versions*** variable is an indicator for whether a journal releases the prior versions of published manuscripts alongside the final one (✓) or not (–). This was verified by inspecting recently published articles at *The BMJ*.

- The information in the **Communication** section comes from a smaller range of sources (Table A.6).
  - The ***Policy on Author Appeals*** variable records whether the journal explicitly states that authors can appeal manuscript decisions (✓) or not (–). Most journals in our sample do this, but the extent to which they have a formal procedure for doing so varies. This information comes from policies on journal websites.
  - The ***Interactive Review*** variable indicates whether the journal reports having established channels for real-time communication between reviewers and authors (✓) or not (–). *Frontiers* is the only journal in our sample that reports having a system of interactive review.

A.5 Journal sourcing table

We use Table A.6 to specify the sources for journal policies that appear in Table 1 and throughout the article.

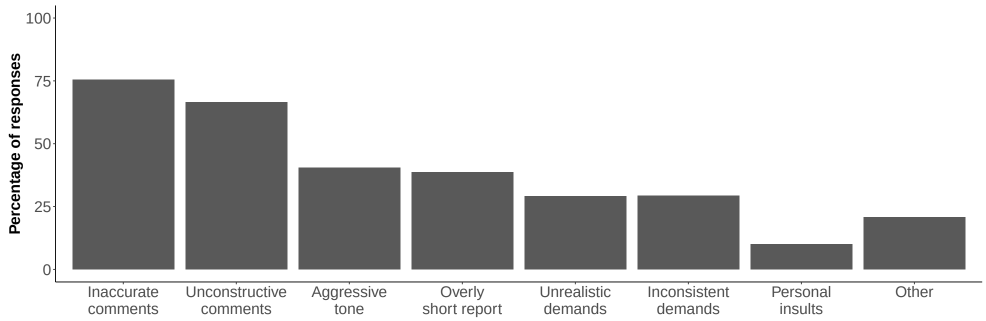
Table A.6: Sources for journal statistics and editorial policies

Journal	Source	Year	Link
American Economic Review	Report of the Editor *AER*	2025	AER-1
	Editorial Policy	2025	AER-2
The BMJ	Resources for reviewers	2025	BMJ-1
	The BMJ's reviewers 2013-2024	2025	BMJ-2
	Competing interest policy	2025	BMJ-3
	Publishing model	2025	BMJ-4
Econometrica	Annual Report 2023-2024 Referees	2025	ECMA-1
	Editorial Procedures	2025	ECMA-2
	Annual Report 2023-2024	2025	ECMA-3
	Bluesky post	2025	ECMA-4
Economic Inquiry	Journal Policies	2025	EI-1
Experimental Economics	Publishing ethics	2025	EX-1
F1000Research	How it Works	2025	F1000-1
Frontiers	Principles of peer review	2025	FRN-1
	Editorial policies and publication ethics	2025	FRN-2
	Annual Report	2025	FRN-3
	Peer Review	2025	FRN-4
JESA	Publishing ethics	2025	JESA-1
Journal of Political Economy	Recent Referees	2025	JPE-1
	ETHICS	2025	JPE-2
	JPE TURNAROUND TIMES	2025	JPE-3
Management Science	Submission Guidelines	2025	MS-1
Nature	Peer Review	2025	NAT-1
	Competing interests	2025	NAT-2
	Journal Metrics	2025	NAT-3
	Editorial criteria and processes	2025	NAT-4
Nature Human Behaviour	Peer Review	2025	NHB-1
Psychological Bulletin	Submission Guidelines	2025	PB-1
Philosophical Review	Submission Guidelines	2025	PR-1
QJE	Acknowledgment of Referees	2025	QJE-1
	Tweet	2025	QJE-2
REStud	Excellence in Refereeing Award	2025	RES-1
	Submissions	2025	RES-2
	Turnaround statistics	2025	RES-3

Journal abbreviations: *JESA* = *Journal of the Economic Science Association*; *QJE* = *Quarterly Journal of Economics*; *REStud* = *Review of Economic Studies.*

B Additional figures and tables referenced in text

Figure B.1: Characteristics of low-quality reports



Notes: Percentages do not add up to 100% as respondents could select multiple reasons (3.1 reasons selected on average). $N = 802$.

Table B.1: Relationships between demographic characteristics and policy attitudes

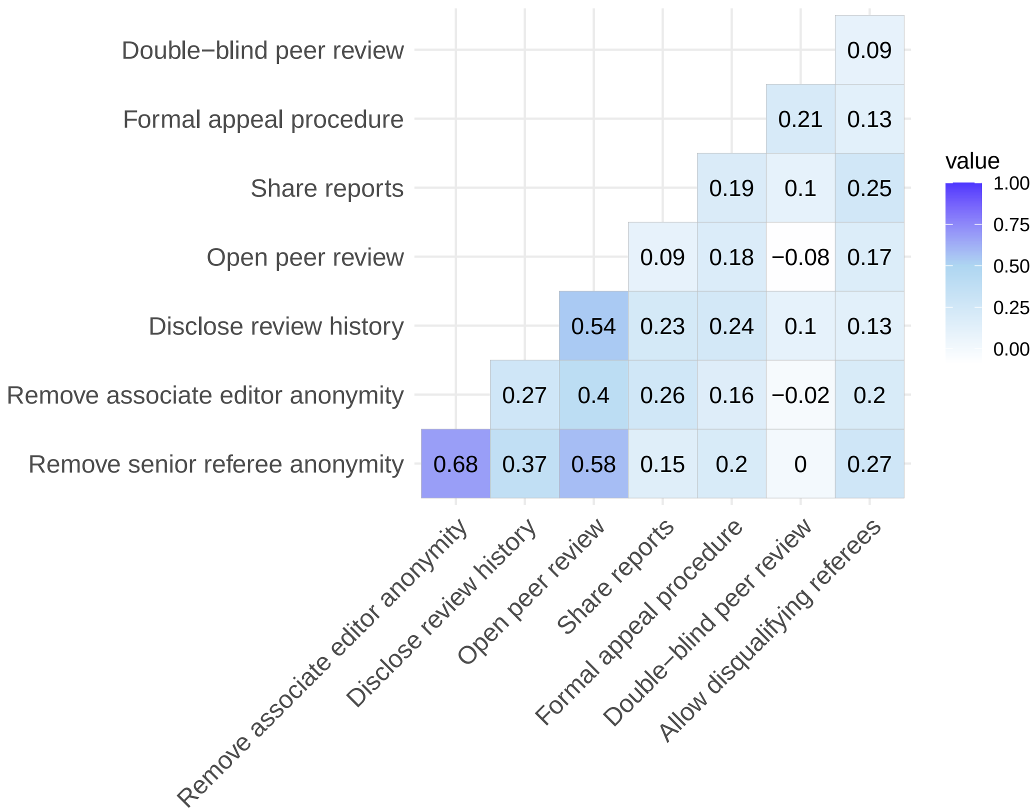
	Double-blind peer review	**Remove senior author anonymity**	**Remove associate editor anonymity**	**Allow disqualifying referees**	**Disclose review history**	**Open peer review**	**Share reports**	**Formal appeal procedure**
Active author	−0.088	0.062	0.152	0.121	−0.077	0.050	−0.020	0.113
	(0.331)	(0.099)	(0.104)	(0.241)	(0.090)	(0.095)	(0.084)	(0.088)
Active reviewer	−0.541	−0.106	0.128	0.314	−0.110	−0.286***	0.061	−0.290***
	(0.357)	(0.113)	(0.119)	(0.260)	(0.103)	(0.108)	(0.096)	(0.101)
Top 5 reviewer	−0.276	−0.348***	−0.307***	−0.251	−0.356***	−0.369***	−0.010	−0.124
	(0.363)	(0.111)	(0.117)	(0.264)	(0.101)	(0.107)	(0.095)	(0.100)
Editor	0.026	−0.006	−0.114	−0.417	−0.117	0.003	−0.028	0.038
	(0.381)	(0.116)	(0.122)	(0.278)	(0.105)	(0.111)	(0.098)	(0.103)
US/Canada	−0.168	−0.034	−0.101	0.194	−0.119	−0.224**	−0.031	−0.033
	(0.326)	(0.109)	(0.115)	(0.237)	(0.099)	(0.104)	(0.093)	(0.097)
Junior	−0.010	0.085	0.063	−0.255	−0.034	−0.187*	0.101	0.109
	(0.399)	(0.116)	(0.123)	(0.290)	(0.106)	(0.111)	(0.099)	(0.104)
Female	0.888**	0.183	0.158	0.234	−0.064	0.148	0.167*	0.056
	(0.342)	(0.114)	(0.121)	(0.249)	(0.104)	(0.109)	(0.097)	(0.102)
Constant	3.175***	2.527***	3.097***	3.879***	3.839***	3.023***	3.874***	3.721***
	(0.404)	(0.116)	(0.118)	(0.294)	(0.101)	(0.107)	(0.095)	(0.100)
N	112	802	802	112	802	802	802	802

Notes: This table presents coefficients from a series of multivariate linear regressions of policy attitudes on demographic characteristics.
* $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$

In the main text, we look at heterogeneity in terms of class membership. In this table, we examine whether there is heterogeneity in support for each individual policy using multivariate OLS regressions. We find that the extent of heterogeneity is modest overall. Top-5 reviewers are less favorable to removing the anonymity of associate editors and senior referees, disclosing review histories, and fully open peer review. Active reviewers are less favorable towards open peer review and having a formal appeal process. Researchers from US/Canada are less likely to support open peer review. Female respondents are more likely to support double-blind review. These results are robust to using an ordered logit specification.[13]

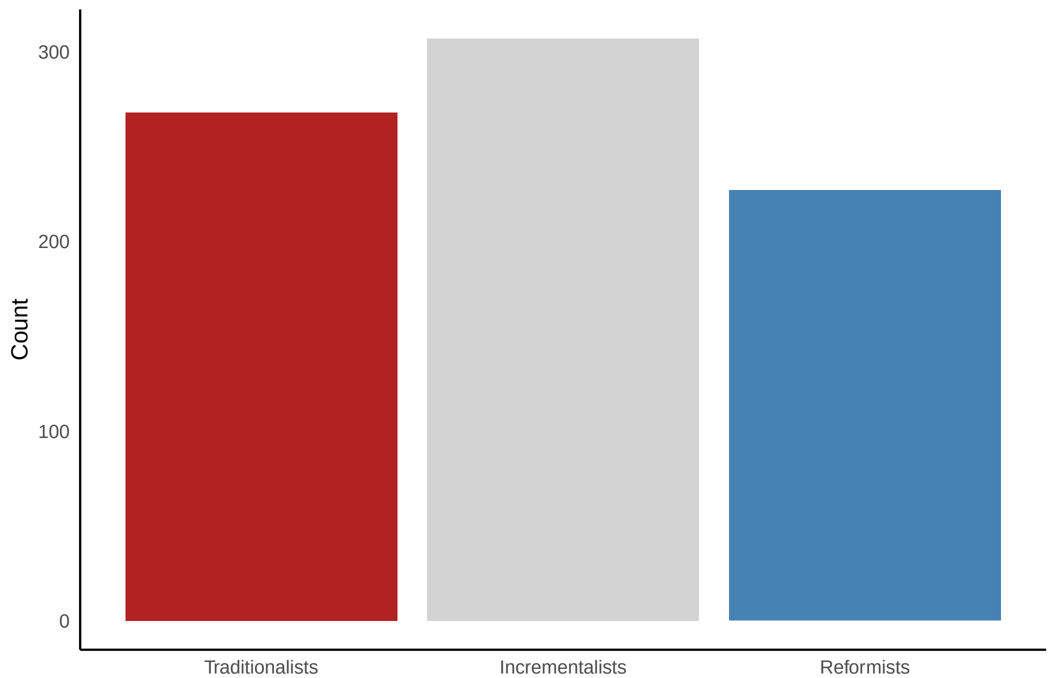
[13]The ordered logit specification results in magnitudes that are somewhat larger and slight differences in significance levels. However, the signs of most of the estimates remain the same, except for a few estimates close to zero. The main exception to this pattern of similarity is for the "share report" policy, where "Female" is statistically significant at the 5% level in the ordered logit specification but is marginally significant in the OLS regression.

Figure B.2: Correlation matrix showing pairwise relationships between survey responses



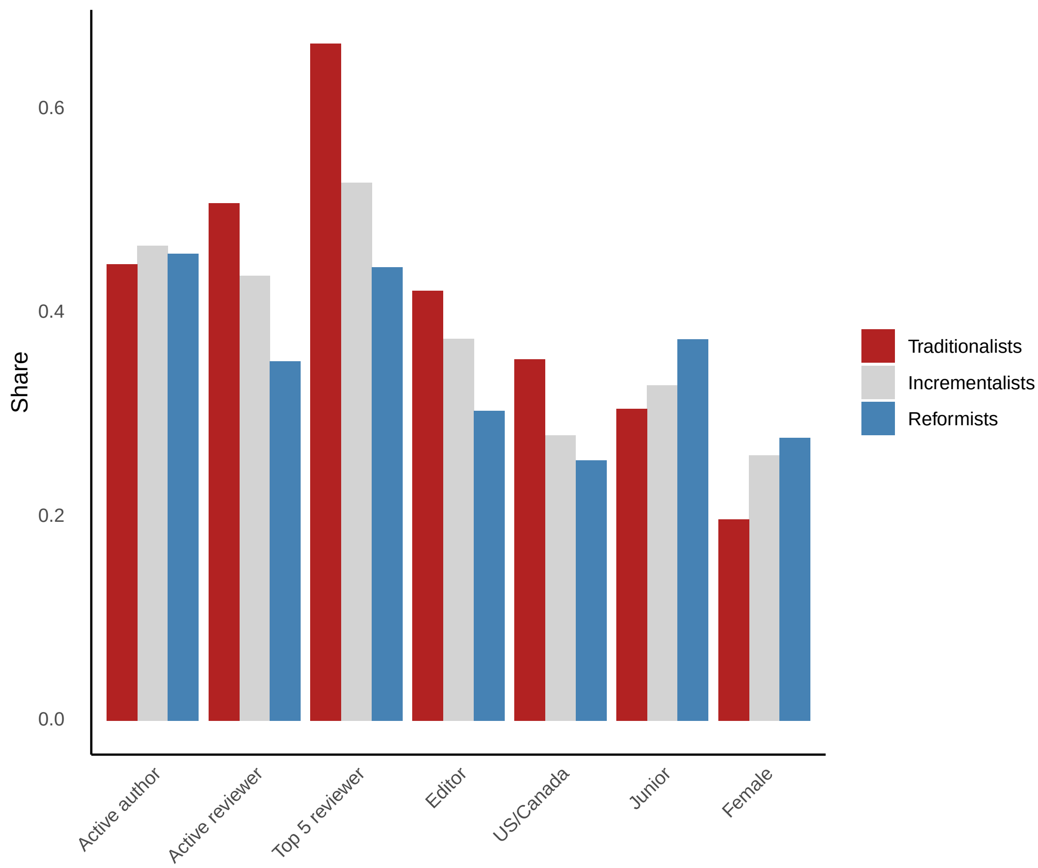
Notes: This figure shows pairwise polychoric correlations between attitudes toward each pair of the main policy questions discussed in the paper. Each correlation is based on the maximum number of observations with non-missing values for both questions in the pair. The sample size is $N = 802$ for most correlations, except for those involving the "disqualifying referees" and "double-blind review" questions, where $N = 112$.

Figure B.3: Number of respondents per LCA class



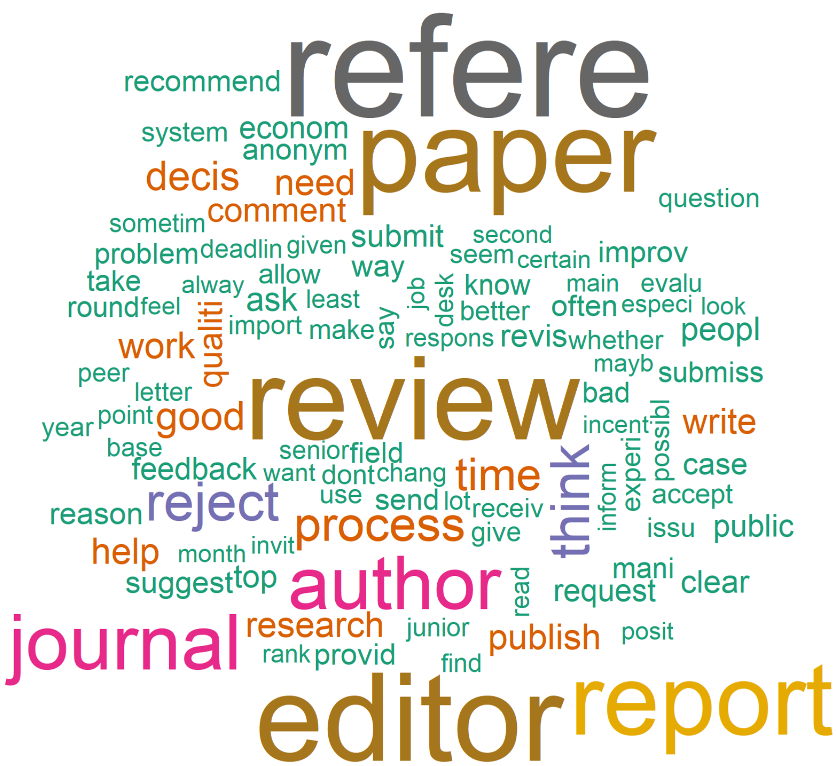
Notes: This figure shows the number of respondents assigned to each of the three classes identified by the latent class analysis (LCA). The shares of respondents in each class are 33%, 38%, and 28% for Traditionalists, Incrementalists, and Reformists, respectively. The classification is based on responses to all of the main policy questions discussed in the paper, except those on "disqualifying referees" and "double-blind review". The sample size is $N = 802$.

Figure B.4: Share of LCA class belonging to each demographic group



Notes: This figure shows the share of respondents in each LCA class who belong to a given demographic group. Each bar represents the share of respondents who belong to a demographic group within a specific class, not the share of the overall sample. The sample size is $N = 802$.

Figure B.5: Frequency of words mentioned in comments



Notes: This figure shows the 100 most frequent words (condensed to their common roots) mentioned in open-text responses to our survey after removing common stop words. The size of each word is proportionate to its frequency. This word cloud combines responses to the questions “Are there other proposals you would like to make to improve the quality of peer reviews or the peer-review process more generally” **[Q21]** and “Please enter below any additional suggestion(s) to improve your experience as a referee” **[Q38]**. This figure is based on 506 comments left by 268 unique respondents.

Figure B.6: Frequency of unique words mentioned in transparency-related comments

Notes: This figure shows the 13 most frequent and unique words (condensed to their common roots) mentioned in transparency-related open-text responses to our survey after removing common stop words. As a first step, all responses were manually categorized into one of 119 categories. Of these, 23 categories corresponding to 113 comments were classified by GPT-4o as transparency-related. Word frequencies were then calculated for transparency- and non-transparency-related comments separately. We then identify uniquely transparency-related words by keeping the most frequent words in the transparency-related comments except for those that also appear in the non-transparency-related comments. The size of each word is proportionate to its frequency. This word cloud combines responses to the questions "Are there other proposals you would like to make to improve the quality of peer reviews or the peer-review process more generally" **[Q21]** and "Please enter below any additional suggestion(s) to improve your experience as a referee" **[Q38]**. For the purpose of clarity, we do not include words that appear less than three times in the transparency comments, but our overall conclusions are not sensitive to this choice.

C Survey questions

Consent Form

Principal Investigators: Gary Charness (UCSB), Anna Dreber (Stockholm School of Economics), and Séverine Toussaert (Oxford)

Description: This is a survey on peer review, which should take about 15-20 minutes of your time. We are interested in your view of the current peer-review process and how it can be improved.

Eligibility Criteria: You are eligible to participate in this survey if, **over the last two years**, (i) you **completed at least one peer review**; and (ii) you **received referee reports** on a paper you submitted for publication in a peer-reviewed journal.

Risks and benefits: There are no physical or emotional risks associated with this study that would go beyond the risks of daily life. Your participation in this study may improve the peer-review process and, therefore, benefit the scientific community. In addition, we will give $100 (cash or gift certificate) to two people drawn randomly from the respondents; you will be asked to leave your email address in a separate survey link if you wish to be entered in the lottery.

Confidentiality: The information collected in this survey may be published in a report or a journal article and presented to interested parties, including possibly, but not exclusively, members of editorial boards or scientific committees. In no circumstances will your identity or personal involvement in this study be disclosed. No personal data (e.g., your IP address) will be collected, except for your email address if you wish to be emailed the report and/or participate in the prize draw (this information will not be connected to your survey responses and will be destroyed after the prize draw). Other information (e.g., survey responses, time of the survey) will be kept by the researchers and may be used for future studies.

Your rights as a participant: Participation is entirely voluntary. You may leave the survey at any time without any penalty or prejudice.

Ethics approval: This research has been reviewed according to the ethics procedures for research involving human subjects of the University of Oxford (approval # ECONCIA-21-21-20). If you wish to raise any concerns about this study to the ethics committee, please email ethics@economics.ox.ac.uk.

Please indicate below that you have read the above, that you meet the eligibility criteria, and that you are willing to participate in this online survey.

Yes, proceed to the survey YES/NO

Your experience of the peer-review process as an author

[Q1]: Over the last two years, how many times did you submit a paper to an economics journal? Please include only first-time submissions (not revisions), with submissions of the same paper to different journals counted separately. [Dropdown with numbers]

[Q2]: How would you rate the overall quality of the referee reports you received over this period? Please indicate what approximate percentage of reports were of the following quality (total should sum to 100):

Very low	[ ]
Fairly low	[ ]
Average	[ ]
Fairly high	[ ]
Very high	[ ]
Total	[100]

[Q3]: What were the characteristics of the low-quality reports? Please tick all that apply:

☐ Inaccurate statements about what the paper does or does not do

☐ Overly short report

☐ Very vague and unconstructive comments

☐ Written with an aggressive tone

☐ Personal insults

☐ Unrealistic demands

☐ Inconsistent demands

☐ Other - please specify: [TEXT BOX]

[Q4]: A referee report can achieve multiple objectives. How important do you consider each of the following objectives? Please rank 1-4 in order of importance (with 1 being most important) by dragging and dropping the various items: [1= most important, 2, 3; 4 = least important]

- Help editor reach an informed decision on the paper
- Give general comments that improve the paper
- Provide detailed feedback on the paper
- Make precise suggestions that improve the paper

[Q5]: As an author, what do you expect from the peer-review process? Please rank 1-3 in order of importance (with 1 being most important): [1 = most important, 2; 3 = least important]

- Getting useful feedback on my work
- A timely decision (whether good or bad)
- Getting a reasonable and well-substantiated decision

Improving the quality of peer reviews

[Q6]: Below is a list of proposals to improve peer reviews. On a scale from 1 to 5, how useful do you find each of them? [1 = not useful at all; 2, 3, 4; 5 = extremely useful]

i. Providing a set of guidelines for writing referee reports.

ii. Providing doctoral training on how to write peer reviews.

iii. Making the history of (anonymous) reviews and authors' responses publicly available.

iv. Removing the anonymity of senior referees.

v. Removing the anonymity of associate editors.

vi. Somehow grading reports and rewarding referees for high-quality reports.

vii. Encouraging the use of a platform that tracks referee activity in a centralized way.

viii. Making all reports available to all of the reviewers and making sure reviewers know this is being done.

Guidelines for writing a report

[Q7]: What type of comments do you find most useful or would you like to see more of? Please make 3 selections from the following list:

☐ Comments about the presentation of the results

☐ Suggestions to improve the existing analysis

☐ Suggestions about possible extensions

☐ Comments that help me clarify the contribution of the paper relative to the literature

☐ Comments about shortening/restructuring the paper

☐ Comments that put in perspective the assumptions made in the paper

☐ Comments about missing previous work and references

☐ Robustness checks

[Q8]: Do you think journals or associations should provide a template for referee reports? [YES/NO]

Information disclosure

[Q9]: In other disciplines, such as public health/medicine, many journals have an open peer-review process: referees sign their reports and the entire review history (including responses to referees) is disclosed. On a scale from 1 to 5, how favorable would you be to an open review policy? [1 = not favorable at all; 2, 3, 4; 5 = very favorable]

[Q10]: What if this only applied to senior reviewers? [1 = not favorable at all; 2, 3, 4; 5 = very favorable]

[Q11]: Another recent trend is to make the history of reports/responses to referees publicly available in an anonymized way unless the reviewers choose to disclose their identity; see e.g., Nature Communcations. On a scale from 1 to 5, how favorable would you be to such a policy? [1 = not favorable at all; 2, 3, 4; 5 = very favorable]

Tracking referee activity

[Q12]: At the moment, there is no centralized system that would allow journal editors to:

- check how many peer-review requests a researcher has recently received across all journals.
- find suitable referees who might be currently available to provide a peer review.

One platform called Publons allows researchers to document their (verified) peer-review activity and to register their interest in doing peer reviews for journals. However, it is not widely used at the moment in economics.

On a scale from 1 to 5, how favorable would you be to the more widespread use of Publons or a similar type of platform? [1 = not favorable at all; 2, 3, 4; 5 = very favorable]

Recognition

[Q13]: Do you think that referees would do a better job if they were better rewarded for their work? [YES/NO]

[Q14]: How should referees be rewarded? Please tick all that apply:

☐ Excellence in refereeing awards based on specific criteria

☐ Payment for timely completion e.g., as at the *American Economic Review*

☐ Discount on submissions to the publisher

☐ Other - please specify: [TEXT BOX]

Improving the peer-review process more generally

[Q15]: What do you think is an appropriate time length to give to reviewers to submit their reports (in weeks)? [Dropdown: From 1 to 16+ weeks]

[Q16]: How do you feel about the policy of having desk rejections? [1 = not favorable at all; 2, 3, 4; 5 = very favorable]

[Q17]: The American Economic Association started a new journal in 2017 called *AER: Insights*. This journal follows a model close to the one of medicine, with the endeavor to accept or reject papers without having to go through a lengthy revision process. Like the papers that *AER: Insights* is looking to publish, reports are supposed to be short and to the point. The whole process is supposed to be fast.

How favorable are you to this type of model? [1 = not favorable at all; 2, 3, 4; 5 = very favorable]

[Q18]: In the case of a rejection, the norm is not to challenge the decision made by the Editor or the views of the referees. This norm is not always followed in practice.

How favorable would you be to a policy allowing the authors to submit a (single) response to the referees and the Editor? The referees would be under no obligation to provide additional comments; a "cooling period" could be required before the authors can send their response. There would be no guarantee of the referees taking this rebuttal into account, and the decision would be final after the comment period. [1 = not favorable at all; 2, 3, 4; 5 = very favorable]

[Q19] (Only included in later survey versions): At journals such as *Management Science*, the review process is double-blind i.e., the identity of both the authors and the referees is kept anonymous. How favorable are you to double-blind reviewing? [1 = not favorable at all; 2, 3, 4; 5 = very favorable]

[Q20] (Only included in later survey versions): In some fields, authors are allowed to suggest that certain reviewers should be disqualified from reviewing their work. How favorable are you to this possibility? [1 = not favorable at all; 2, 3, 4; 5 = very favorable]

[Q21]: Are there other proposals you would like to make to improve the quality of peer reviews or the peer-review process more generally? [TEXT BOX]

Your experience of the peer-review process as a referee

[Q22]: On average, approximately how many referee reports do you write per year? [Dropdown with numbers]

[Q23]: What percentage of the time do you write referee reports for the following types of journals? (total should sum to 100):

Top-5 journal [ ]

Top field journal [ ]

Other journal in Economics [ ]

Journals in other disciplines [ ]

Total [100]

[Q24]: Have you occupied or are you currently occupying an editorial position? [YES/NO]

[Q25]: Usually, how much time do you spend on a referee report, including reading the paper and writing the report? [Dropdown: Less than one hour, 1 or 2 hours, Half a working day, 1 day, 2 days, More than 2 days]

[Q26]: Over the past two years, what percentage of the time were you late submitting a referee report? [0, 10, 20, 30, 40, 50, 60, 70, 80, 90, 100]

[Q27] [*If Q26 answer* > 0]: On average, what was your delay? [Dropdown: 1 day, More than 1 day & less than 1 week, 1-2 weeks, 3-4 weeks, More than a month]

[Q28]: What do you think is a reasonable number of reports to be assigned per year? [Dropdown with numbers]

[Q29]: Did you reject a request to referee over these past two years? [YES/NO]

[Q30]: How many times did you reject a request to referee? [Dropdown with numbers]

[Q31]: What were the main reasons? Please tick all that apply:

☐ Conflict of interest
☐ Inability to judge the paper
☐ Too remote from your research field
☐ Lack of time
☐ Low quality paper
☐ Lower-ranked journal
☐ Other - please specify: [TEXT BOX]

[Q32]: How many times did you feel tempted to decline a report even if you ended up fulfilling the request? [Dropdown with numbers]

[Q33]: When you were tempted to decline a report, what were the main reasons? Please tick all that apply:

☐ Conflict of interest

☐ Inability to judge the paper

☐ Too remote from your research field

☐ Lack of time

☐ Low quality paper

☐ Lower-ranked journal

☐ Other - please specify: [TEXT BOX]

[Q34]: How do you feel about people refereeing papers by co-authors or friends?

- This should never happen.
- This should happen as little as possible but cannot be avoided sometimes.
- This is not a problem as long as the editor is aware of the potential conflict of interest.
- This is not a problem and there is no reason to inform the editor.

[Q35]: What do you see as the biggest benefits of being a referee? Please rank 1-5 in order of importance (with 1 being most important) by dragging and dropping the various items: [1 = most important; 2, 3, 4; 5 = least important]

i. I can help to ensure the right papers are published or rejected

ii. I can get to know the editors and make myself known.

iii. I can learn from the opinion of the other referees and the editor.

iv. I can attentively read papers I would never read otherwise.

v. Being a referee makes me a better writer.

[Q36]: How important do you consider your role as a referee? [1 = most important; 2, 3, 4; 5 = least important]

[Q37]: How could your experience as a referee be improved? Please rank 1-4 in order of importance [1 = most important; 2, 3; 4 = least important]

i. There is a global annual limit on how many papers I am requested to review.

ii. The editors give clear guidance of what they would like to learn from my report.

iii. The editors systematically share their decision and the other reports.

iv. The editors assign me only papers that are related to my research.

[Q38]: Please enter below any additional suggestion(s) to improve your experience as a referee: [TEXT BOX]

A little more about you

[Q39]: How many papers have you published in your career up to now? Please indicate a ballpark estimate. [TEXT BOX]

[Q40]: What are your key areas of research? Please select all that apply:

- Applied econometrics
- Applied microeconomics
- Behavioral economics
- Decision theory
- Development economics
- Economic history
- Econometric theory
- Experimental economics
- Financial economics
- Game theory
- Industrial organization
- International trade
- Labor economics
- Macroeconomics
- Microeconomic theory
- Political economy
- Public economics
- Structural econometrics

- Urban economics
- Other - indicate: [TEXT BOX]

[Q41]: What is your gender? [Dropdown: Male, Female, Other, Prefer not to say]

[Q42]: What is your age? [Dropdown: Under 30, 30-39, 40-49, 50-59, 60-69, 70+, Prefer not to say]

[Q43]: What is your position? [Dropdown: PhD candidate, Post-doctoral researcher, Assistant professor, Associate professor, Full professor, Prefer not to say]

[Q44]: In what country is your job located? [Dropdown]

[Q45]: Finally, if you have any comments about the survey itself, feel free to add in the text box below: [TEXT BOX]